

THE FEAR NOT'S OF CHRISTMAS

Christmas is a season when everyone should be on there best behavior. As you know, Santa is *“Making a list and checking it twice to see who has been naughty or nice.”* At Christmas folks seem to be kind to people that, well, they really don't even like.

Christmas is supposed to be the *“Most Wonderful Time Of The Year.”* For the most part this is true but in actuality it also seems to bring out the worst:

- In relationships...
- In families...
- In organizations...
- In business...
- In churches...

Many of the aforementioned problems are brought on by fear. The fear that exists in this world is overwhelming.

Years ago, Ann Landers who received in excess of 10,000 letters a week was once asked, *"What is the most common problem that you are asked to deal with?"* She said, *"Without a doubt -- fear."*

This is the age of anxiety, everybody's afraid of something. A little boy asked his Dad, *"Daddy, are you afraid of spiders?"* His Dad said, *"No."* He continued, *"Are you afraid of robbers?"* Again the answer was *"No."* The kid persisted, *"Are you afraid of thunder?"* The father replied, *"No."* Not to be deterred the child asked *"Are you afraid of ghosts?"* A bit impatiently the dad said *"Absolutely not."* To which the child replied, *"Then I guess, Mommy's the only thing you're afraid of."*

In 1933, FDR said, *"We have nothing to fear but fear itself."* That sounds plausible but it's just not true. A study was conducted with 500 people and found 7,000 different

fears, which averaged 14 fears per person. There are a lot of things to be afraid of.

Paul Tournier in his book *“The Strong and the Weak”* said, *“Fear creates what it fears.”* If one fears becoming like a parent, if that fear is not conquered there is a better than good chance they will become just like the parent. (My experience going to class to get my motorcycle license – The way to make a short turn on a bike is to look at where you want to go)

The Bible has a lot to say about fear. In fact, the Bible says more about fear than it does about heaven or heaven or hell. God wants us to overcome all fear. Psalm 34:4 (KJV) ***“I sought the Lord, and He heard me, and delivered me from all my fears.”*** The word of the Lord to you today is that you can be released from all fear.

Paul Tournier say's, *“All of us have reservoirs of full potential, vast areas of great satisfaction. But the roads that lead to those reservoirs are guarded by the dragon of fear.”*

Fear is worry out of control. Philippians 4:6 (KJV) ***“Be anxious for nothing, but in everything by prayer and supplication, with thanksgiving, let your requests be made known to God”*** When we place our fears in Gods hands we take it out of the devils hands. One thing is for sure; we can break free of our fears with the help of the Lord.

I. THE FEAR NOT OF UNANSWERED PRAYER

Luke 1:5-7 (NKJV) ***“There was in the days of Herod, the king of Judea, a certain priest named Zacharias, of the division of Abijah. His wife was of the daughters of Aaron, and her name was Elizabeth. ⁶ And they were both righteous before God,***

walking in all the commandments and ordinances of the Lord blameless. ⁷ But they had no child, because Elizabeth was barren, and they were both well advanced in years.”

Elizabeth and Zacharias had been married for many years and for all practical purposes were past the baby stage. Listen to the sad words of Luke 1:7 (NKJV) ***“They had no child, because Elizabeth was barren, and they were both well advanced in years.”***

It is a bit comical to read the statement of Zacharias in Luke 1:18 ***“I am an old man and my wife is well advanced in years.”*** Notice Zacharias said he was old but he did not say the same about Elizabeth! Smart man! (Story of Heath Jones talking to his mom and sister)

This couple had no doubt poured their hearts out to God concerning their barrenness, yet

they remained childless. They probably:

- Picked out baby names, but no baby...
- Shopped for baby clothes, but no baby came...
- Fixed up a nursery, but no baby appeared...

Month after month they prayed and hoped only to be disappointed by the news of a negative pregnancy test, Elizabeth was not pregnant! It probably appeared to them that their prayers had not been answered and that they would never know the joys of parenthood.

In Old Testament times barrenness was considered to be a curse. Zacharias and Elizabeth no doubt lived under the cloud of suspicion that something must be wrong with them, that would cause them to be unfit for parenthood or God would surely give them have a child. Wouldn't He?

Painting ones life with such a broad brush is rarely accurate and can cause a great deal of unnecessary self-loathing. Beating oneself up is never a productive exercise. Engaging in such an activity is self-defeating.

I'm sure Zacharias and Elizabeth had long periods of introspection to see if there was anything in their lives that would prevent their prayers from being answered. When it seems that our prayers are being blocked we should take time for reflection and introspection. But to assign blame inward when there is no apparent sin is an unwise exercise. Self-loathing counteracts faith and anything that hinders faith is the enemy of God. Romans 14:23 (NKJV) “*Whatever is not from faith is sin.*”

I want to list a few reasons for unanswered prayer:

- Sinful actions...
- Doubt and unbelief...

- Un-forgiveness...
- Rebellion against authority...
- Praying outside the will of God...
- Praying with wrong motives...

When one has determined that all negative reasons for prayers not being answered have been resolved, continuing to wallow in self-pity is never productive! Once we have determined the problem is not on our end we should rise up in faith and claim the promises!

The problem with unanswered prayers had nothing to do with anything negative in the life of Zacharias and Elizabeth. Luke 1:6 (NKJV) ***“They were both righteous before God, walking in all the commandments and ordinances of the Lord blameless.”***

I do not know whether Zacharias and Elizabeth were wallowing in self-pity but one thing is for sure; they had suffered

through the brutality of unrequited dreams of parenthood. Though they were found to be righteous, there was still the issue of unanswered prayer.

At this point we must remind ourselves that there are some positive reasons that our prayers seem to go unanswered:

- Faith is being put to the test...
- God is working while we are waiting...
- The timing is not quite right...
- The answer is already on its way...

It turns out that in the case of Zacharias and Elisabeth wanting to be parents, all of the above was true! Their faith was being tested. Because of the calling of John the Baptist, they were going to need all the faith they could acquire so God was making faith deposits during the years of barrenness.

God was in fact working while they were waiting!

The timing of their pregnancy was of utmost importance because John the Baptist was to be the forerunner of Jesus!

While they were thinking the window of parenthood had passed them by, the answer was on its way into their lives.

For most of us the same thing is true. We want God to operate on our schedule but we must learn to operate on His! Ecclesiastes 3:1 (NKJV) ***“To everything there is a season, A time for every purpose under heaven”***

Gabriel appeared to Zacharias and declared, Luke 1:13 (KJV) ***“Fear not, Zacharias: for thy prayer is heard; and thy wife Elisabeth shall bear thee a son, and thou shalt call his name John”*** This Scripture proves, though Zacharias was a man of God doing the work of God he was fearful that his

greatest petition would never be answered. Have you ever been there? Are you there now?

Zacharias was so shocked by the appearance and message of Gabriel that he allowed himself to speak a doubtful statement into the moment. Luke 1:18 (NKJV) ***“Zacharias said to the angel, “How shall I know this? For I am an old man, and my wife is well advanced in years.”*** This statement of unbelief earned Zacharias nine months of silence. Could it be that God had to zip the lip of Zacharias for nine months to prevent him from talking himself out of his miracle?

The same was true of the Israelites at Jericho! The last time the Israeli people were in Canaan they talked themselves right out of there, and into forty-plus-years of wilderness wandering! When God and Joshua got them to Jericho they both agreed the people should not talk for seven day’s

and then only to shout praise to God! God and Joshua did not want to run the risk of the people once again, talking themselves out of the land ***“Flowing with milk and honey.”***

How many times have we talked ourselves out of a miracle or allowed fear to prevent our prayers from being answered?

I speak into all of our lives today, rehearsing the words of Gabriel, ***“Fear not, your prayer has been heard.”***

II. THE FEAR NOT OF HUMAN IMPOSSIBILITY

Luke 1:26-35 (KJV) ***“in the sixth month the angel Gabriel was sent from God unto a city of Galilee, named Nazareth, ²⁷ To a virgin espoused to a man whose name was Joseph, of the house of David; and the virgin's name was Mary. ²⁸ And the angel came in unto her, and said, Hail, thou that***

art highly favoured, the Lord is with thee: blessed art thou among women. ²⁹ And when she saw him, she was troubled at his saying, and cast in her mind what manner of salutation this should be. ³⁰ And the angel said unto her, Fear not, Mary: for thou hast found favour with God. ³¹ And, behold, thou shalt conceive in thy womb, and bring forth a son, and shalt call his name JESUS. ³² He shall be great, and shall be called the Son of the Highest: and the Lord God shall give unto him the throne of his father David: ³³ And he shall reign over the house of Jacob for ever; and of his kingdom there shall be no end. ³⁴ Then said Mary unto the angel, How shall this be, seeing I know not a man? ³⁵ And the angel answered and said unto her, The Holy Ghost shall come upon thee, and the power of the Highest shall overshadow thee: therefore also that holy thing which shall be born of thee shall be called the Son of God.”

Let us take a few moments and place ourselves in Mary's place. Mary had saved herself for marriage; she was a virgin! She had made the protection of her reputation a very high priority. She had never been with a man and the only way a child had ever been conceived is for a man and a woman to engage in intimate contact.

If the words of the angel were to come to pass she would lose her reputation and become the object of suspicion, innuendo and gossip.

Think of the questions flooding the mind of Mary:

- How can this be?
- Why am I the one?
- What about Joseph?
- What will people think?
- Who would believe this story?

The words of the angel were over the line of human impossibility! Yet, listen to the admonition of the angel. “***Fear not, Mary: for thou hast found favour with God.***” The angel was asking Mary to step into an arena that no human being had ever ventured into in the history of the world! Mary was about to:

- Go off the chain...
- Travel beyond the map...
- Sail into uncharted waters...
- Traverse the limits of human history...
- Test the very limits of human impossibility...

Yet, Gabriel say’s to her, “***The Holy Ghost shall come upon thee, and the power of the Highest shall overshadow thee: therefore also that holy thing which shall be born of thee shall be called the Son of God.***”

Notice three very important things:

- The Holy Ghost was to come upon Mary...
- The power of the Highest was to overshadow Mary...
- The Son of God would be the result of the arrangement between Heaven and earth...

Galatians 4:4 (KJV) ***“But when the fullness of time was come, God sent forth his Son, made of a woman, made under the law.”***

The miracle of the incarnation of Christ is that He was 100% God and 100% man simultaneously.

The ultimate in human impossibility looked like this:

- God's Son became Mary's Baby...
- A child was born, but a son man was given....
- The Lion of the Tribe of Judah became a lamb slain from the foundation of the

world... (From everlasting to everlasting
– Eternal Priesthood after the order –
Before Abraham was, I am)

- An equal to God became a lowly servant of all mankind...
- The Ancient of Days became an infant born in Bethlehem's stable...
- The Omnipotent became a dependant life to be fed, clothed and nourished by human hands...
- He placed himself in the hands of man, that man might place himself in the hands of God... (Cast yourselves upon the mercies of God – His mercies are new every morning)
- He became sin so the sinful could be forgiven...
- He was bruised so we could be healed...
- He endured turmoil so we could have peace...
- He was rejected so we could be accepted...

- He came to earth so we could go to heaven...
- He became hungry so the hungry could be fed...
- He became thirsty so the thirsty could be satisfied...

Think of this:

- On His Mothers side He wept at the tomb of His friend Lazarus, on His Fathers side He called Lazarus back to life...
- On His Mothers side it was necessary to maintain hydration, on His Fathers side He offered water that would quench thirst for time and eternity...
- On His Mothers side He was thirty years old when He entered public ministry, on His Fathers side He was present when the morning stars sang together and the sons of God shouted for joy... (Where was Jesus from 12-30?)

- On His Mothers side He was thirty-three and one half years old, on His Fathers side He was the Ancient of Days...
- On His Mothers side He died an early death, on His Fathers side He abolished death...
- On His Mothers side He was buried in a borrowed tomb, on His Fathers side He is the resurrection and the life...
- On His Mothers side He was subject to His parents, on His Fathers side God gave Him a name above all other names...
- On His Mothers side He rode a donkey or walked everywhere He went, on His Fathers side He rides on the wings of the wind...
- On His Mothers side He used a candle to dispel the darkness of night, on His Fathers side He lit the world three days before He created the sun, moon and stars...

- On His Mothers side He could not light one room at a time, on His Fathers side He will be the light of a city that is built two thousand miles square...
- On His Mothers side He could only be in one place at a time, on His Fathers side He is omnipresent...
- On His Mothers side He had to rely upon the facts He could see, on His Fathers side He is omniscient...
- On His Mothers side He broke under the weight of the cross, on His Fathers side He is omnipotent...
- On His Mother's side He was a lamb led to His own slaughter, on His Fathers side He was the Lion of the Tribe of Judah...
- On His Mothers side He did not open His mouth in His own defense, on His Fathers side He possessed the power to call twelve legions of angels to His own rescue...
- On His Mothers side He tolerated injustice and aggression, on His Fathers

side He treads out the wine press of the wrath of God and breaks mighty armies across His knees...

- On His Mothers side He was Jesus, Mary's boy, on His Fathers side He is King of Kings and Lord of Lords...
- On His Mothers side He never had his name in lights, on His Fathers side He will reign forever...
- On His Mothers side He was never elected to high office, on His Fathers side He will rule over Heaven and Earth...
- On His Mothers side He was of no reputation, on His Fathers side every knee shall bow and every tongue shall confess He is Lord to the glory of God the Father...

Mary faced up to the overwhelming onslaught of human impossibility and gave birth to the Messiah. God anointed Mary to walk the trail of difficulty so that she could

experience the reality of the greatest miracle the world would ever know.

The impossibility you face today is making a place for a miracle of God to be brought to fruition in your life.

III. THE FEAR NOT OF OBEDIENCE

Matthew 1:18-25 (KJV) “*Now the birth of Jesus Christ was on this wise: When as his mother Mary was espoused to Joseph, before they came together, she was found with child of the Holy Ghost. ¹⁹ Then Joseph her husband, being a just man, and not willing to make her a public example, was minded to put her away privily. ²⁰ But while he thought on these things, behold, the angel of the LORD appeared unto him in a dream, saying, Joseph, thou son of David, fear not to take unto thee Mary thy wife: for that which is conceived in her is of the Holy Ghost. ²¹ And she shall bring forth a son, and thou shalt call his name*

JESUS: for he shall save his people from their sins. ²² Now all this was done, that it might be fulfilled which was spoken of the Lord by the prophet, saying, ²³ Behold, a virgin shall be with child, and shall bring forth a son, and they shall call his name Emmanuel, which being interpreted is, God with us. ²⁴ Then Joseph being raised from sleep did as the angel of the Lord had bidden him, and took unto him his wife: ²⁵ And knew her not till she had brought forth her firstborn son: and he called his name JESUS.”

If you were given the opportunity to meet any person in the first Christmas story, whom would you choose? There are so many fascinating people:

- Herod – A wicked King, jealous of a Baby in a manger...
- The Magi –The Wise Men from the East...

- The Innkeeper – Out of room and probably out of patience...
- The Shepherds – They may have been teenagers - Nearly all the shepherds in modern Israel are teenagers, many of them are girls...
- Anna - The prophetess...
- The angels – What an announcement...
- Zacharias and Elisabeth – The father and mother of John the Baptist.
- Mary – The mother of Jesus, what a woman...
- Simeon - Who took baby Jesus in his arms and blessed his parents...
- Joseph – Joseph? I almost forgot about Joseph!

Joseph is an all but overlooked figure in this story but the part he played in this epic event is unforgettable. The role of Joseph in all of this was to be the husband of Mary and the foster father of Jesus. I would love to have

the opportunity to meet Joseph. What an interesting conversation that would be! I have lots of questions for Joseph:

- How did you handle the announcement?
- How difficult was it to withstand the insults?
- Did you ever consider making a dash for the door?
- How did this affect the rest of your life going forward?

Joseph is the forgotten character of the Christmas story. It appears that Joseph rubbed himself down with invisible cream; he vanishes from the story after his initial visit with the angel.

Very little is said about Joseph in the Bible. Rarely ever is a sermon preached about him. As a matter of fact, there's just not much written about Joseph at all.

This is what we know about Joseph:

- His father was Jacob...
- His ancestral hometown was Bethlehem...
- He lived in Nazareth...
- He was from the royal line of David...
- He was a carpenter by trade...
- He was a poor man... We know that because when he and Mary presented Jesus in the Temple, they brought a turtledove to sacrifice. Jews only did that when they could not afford a lamb.
- He was a religious man...
- He was probably in his late teens...

Mary and Joseph were engaged, yet her announcement to him was that she was pregnant! Pregnant? Really? The one thing Joseph knew for sure was that he was not the father!

This could only mean one thing; she had been unfaithful to their commitment to each

other. The initial pain must have felt like a ton of bricks falling on him.

Joseph had a decision to make, he could have her stoned to death; he could very privately break his engagement with her; or he could marry her.

Was Joseph:

- Angry?
- Shamed?
- Confused?
- Embarrassed?
- Disappointed?

Have you ever wondered, what did he say to her? Better yet, what did she say to him? Did she tell him about the angel Gabriel? If she did, can you blame him for not believing her?

Put yourself in Joseph's shoes. You're a teenager in love and suddenly your girl

friend turns up pregnant. You aren't the father but you don't know who is. What do you do? If you're a typical American teenager, you give her \$200 to go get an abortion. It's easy, it's quick, it's cheap, and just like that, you can make the problem go away. A half-million teenage girls take that option every year it's the preferred solution for what people call an "unwanted pregnancy."

Thankfully, Joseph and Mary didn't have that option, abortion was very rare in ancient Israel and Planned Parenthood hadn't opened up a clinic in Nazareth yet.

Joseph's dilemma was very different, he was a devout Jew and under the Law he had the right to break his engagement to Mary for unfaithfulness. In fact, the Law forbade him to marry her under those circumstances. Here is the greatness of Joseph; he loved Mary so much that even though she had

made the horrible announcement of her pregnancy, his thoughts were dedicated to what would be best for her!

Listen to Matthew's description of the actions of Joseph. Matthew 1:19 (KJV)
“Then Joseph her husband, being a just man, and not willing to make her a public example, was minded to put her away privily.” Please understand that this is the posture of Joseph prior to his encounter with the angel! All he had to go on was the word of Mary! Joseph:

- Committed himself to doing the right thing...
- Had no desire to humiliate Mary...
- Decided to deal with Mary privately...

Wow! What a guy! Are there any single women in the room looking for a Joseph? Any of you married women wanting to transition your man into a Joseph?

Joseph first had the right attitude, then Joseph entertained an angel, and the angel said, “***Joseph, thou son of David, fear not to take unto thee Mary thy wife: for that which is conceived in her is of the Holy Ghost.*** ²¹ ***And she shall bring forth a son, and thou shalt call his name JESUS: for he shall save his people from their sins.”***

Matthew 1:20-21 (KJV)

Think of this, the angel appeared one time to Joseph and spoke less than a paragraph, forty-nine words to be exact, and Joseph immediately responded to a request from Father God to be the foster dad to His Son! This one act would change everything about Joseph’s life forever.

Listen to the “***Fear not***” of obedience.

Listen to this, “***Then Joseph being raised from sleep did as the angel of the Lord had bidden him, and took unto him his wife:***

²⁵ ***And knew her not till she had brought***

forth her firstborn son: and he called his name JESUS.” Matthew 1:24-25

What a great man of faith and obedience. Most people assume that the story of Joseph ends right there but it is far from over. From this point on, every action Joseph took testified to his greatness:

- By marrying her quickly he broke all Jewish custom, but he protected Mary’s reputation...
- By making sure she remained a virgin until Jesus was born, he protected the integrity of the miracle of Jesus’ conception by the Holy Spirit...
- By naming the baby he exercised a father’s prerogative and officially received Jesus into his family, as his own legal son...

In these days of confusion, Joseph is a wonderful model of what a godly man looks like:

- He was tough, when he could have been weak...
- He was understanding, when he could have been harsh...
- He was thoughtful, when he could have been hasty...
- He was trusting, when he could have doubted...
- He was temperate, when he could have indulged himself...

Though the angel said, “***Fear not to take Mary to be your wife***” the onus of that decision rested squarely on the shoulders of Joseph.

Almost always when we are called upon to obey, we do not necessarily understand why. The responsibility is ours to step up to the fear not of obedience and trust God as we move forward into uncharted territory.

Isaiah 55:9 (NKJB) “***For as the heavens are higher than the earth, So are My ways***”

higher than your ways, And My thoughts
than your thoughts.”

Philippians 4:6-7 (CEV) **“Don’t worry**
about anything, but pray about everything.
With thankful hearts offer up your prayers
and requests to God. ⁷ Then, because you
belong to Christ Jesus, God will bless you
with peace that no one can completely
understand. And this peace will control the
way you think and feel.”

We may not understand everything we are called upon to walk through but if we will face each circumstance as Joseph did, not fearing obedience; God will certainly bring our journey to a good end. I cannot explain the circumstances but I accept my present position in life as the will of God for me. If I am in His will He will do more with my journey than I can imagine. Ephesians 3:20-21 (NKJV) ***“Now to Him who is able to do***
exceedingly abundantly above all that we

ask or think, according to the power that works in us, ²¹ to Him be glory in the church by Christ Jesus to all generations, forever and ever. Amen.” This phrase “*Exceeding abundantly*” is a fun phrase in the original language. Paul uses a double compound word; in fact, he makes up his own word phrase. He is so caught up in the enormity of God that he creates a new word phrase to make his point. He stacks these words one upon another in an attempt to say, God is not just big:

- He is big-uhmundo-huge-a-riffic
- He is fan-awe-stical-some
- He is magni-great-more-big-fully
- He is super-beyond-erful
- He is incredi-outrag-i-dible!”

In Ephesians 3:20 Paul is morphing words together to make his point! He is saying that God is:

- Ably able...
- Amazingly Amazing...

- Awesomely awesome...
- Extravagantly extravagant...
- Fantastically fantastical...
- Indescribably indescribable.
- Infinitely infinite...
- Incredibly incredible...
- Outrageously outrageous...

Joseph discovered, and we know, God always exceeds expectations! With God, we always get more than we expect:

- He didn't just make a single drop of water He created oceans of water...
- He didn't create one lone star (No matter what Texan's think) God masterminded and created galaxies...
- He didn't just design a hill, God made mountain ranges...
- He didn't just make the sun, God designed sunsets and sunrises....

In God's world there are no limits or

boundaries:

- There are no boundaries to His blessings...
- There are no containers that can hold His compassion...
- There are no fences impeding His faithfulness...
- There are no guardrails standing between His grace and us...
- There are no lines separating us from His presence...
- There are no limitations to experiencing His life...

If we can step up to the “*Fear not*” of obedience every blessing can be ours!

IV. THE FEAR NOT OF SALVATION

Luke 2:8-11 (NKJV) “*And there were in the same country shepherds abiding in the field, keeping watch over their flock by night. ⁹ And, lo, the angel of the Lord came upon them, and the glory of the Lord shone*

round about them: and they were sore afraid. ¹⁰ And the angel said unto them, Fear not: for, behold, I bring you good tidings of great joy, which shall be to all people. ¹¹ For unto you is born this day in the city of David a Saviour, which is Christ the Lord.”

What a shock it must have been to those shepherds tending sheep on the Judean Hills to suddenly experience such a supernatural phenomena. Shepherds were not used to being on the cutting edge of such announcement, they were peasants who usually learned of such things around a campfire, listening to the folklore tales of the ancient dusty past.

The interesting dynamic of that first Christmas was that for many generations throughout the Old Testament, there was always a remnant of Jewish people who waited every single day for Messiah to

come.

The reason they waited for Messiah was based on the hundreds of prophecies throughout the Old Testament:

- ***“And I will put enmity between you and the woman, And between your seed and her Seed; He shall bruise your head, And you shall bruise His heel.”***

Genesis 3:15 (KJV)

- ***“But you, Bethlehem Ephrathah, Though you are little among the thousands of Judah, Yet out of you shall come forth to Me The One to be Ruler in Israel, Whose goings forth are from of old, From everlasting.”*** Micah 5:2 (KJV)

- ***“Therefore the Lord Himself will give you a sign: Behold, the virgin shall conceive and bear a Son, and shall call His name Immanuel.”*** Isaiah 7:14 (KJV)

The Old Testament is full of hundreds of prophecies about the Messiah but after the Old Testament was completed, there were four hundred silent years before Jesus Christ was born, a time where many people gave up waiting. Four hundred years that were accentuated by:

- No prophecies...
- No dreams...
- No visions...
- No angels...
- No heavenly experiences...

Let me put this in perspective. Would we be a bit discouraged if we had not heard from God about our promise since 1612?

In fact, morally, spiritually, and culturally it was a dark hour when Jesus Christ was born. ***"Darkness covered the earth."*** Just like today, the shadows were deeper in some lands than in others; some minds were more lost and buried in the thick darkness than

others were.

Judaism had passed out of its manhood into its declining years, out of its strength and spirituality into a dreary and lifeless formalism. It had, indeed, escaped from idolatry, and it was free from the worst excesses of the pagan world; but it was far from embracing the idea of a Messiah who would come with healing for the body, soul, and spirit of humankind.

It was against this backdrop the shepherds were paid a visit from the angel, and the Glory of God. The shepherds received the usual angel greeting, “*Fear not.*” That’s easy for angels to say but more complicated for shepherds to do especially when you connect the angel greeting with the fact that they showed up without warning and appeared suddenly! When the angel arrived He did so in a cloud of “*The glory of God.*”

Those of us who sit here today considering the story of the shepherds have a difficult time grasping the gravity of what the shepherds were experiencing:

- We have the benefit of the entirety of the Word of God; they did not...
- We know the angel was not there to harm them; they did not...
- We know the angel was delivering good news; they did not...
- We know the rest of the story; they did not...

We could get caught up in the fact that the shepherds entertained an angel, but the real story is what the angel said. ***“And the angel said unto them, Fear not: for, behold, I bring you good tidings of great joy, which shall be to all people. ¹¹ For unto you is born this day in the city of David a Saviour, which is Christ the Lord.”***

The real message to the shepherds was,
“Fear not, the savior has come to bring salvation.”

The salvation this child would bring would change the course of religion but more importantly the course of humankind. The change that He would bring would be clearly seen in six distinct ways:

- The nature and the disposition of God – This child would mark the end of one dispensation of time and the beginning of another – BC vs. AD - Law vs. Grace – FEAR NOT SALVATION HAS COME!
- The character and the consequences of sin – Sin would no longer be rolled ahead a year at a time, it would be forgiven once and for all – FEAR NOT SALVATION HAS COME!
- The way back to God and righteousness – No more blood of sheep, bulls, and goats – One sacrifice for sin forever –

FEAR NOT SALVATION HAS COME!

- The transcendent value of the human soul – God gave all when He gave Jesus – Why? To redeem the soul of fallen man “*For God so loved the world...*” - FEAR NOT SALVATION HAS COME!
- The beauty and joy of a life of consecration – Under law, man was always doing and never done – Because of this child, man could now rest in the righteousness of God, and allow that righteousness to control behavior – FEAR NOT SALVATION HAS COME!
- The certainty of future glory to the good and faithful – Under law one could never be sure his/her eternity had been sealed – Because of this child eternity’s ticket could be punched - The deal was signed sealed and delivered – FEAR NOT SALVATION HAS COME!